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Through Ngoni Eyes

Margaret Read's matrilineal interpretations from Nyasaland¹

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Abstract ■ Drawing upon a significant amount of unpublished data which Margaret Read collected as a part of the 1939 Nyasaland Nutrition Survey and her simultaneous study on the impact of migrant labor on village life in Nyasaland, this article argues that her conclusions that matrilineal practices were being taken over by patrilineal ones is not borne out by the evidence she collected. As peoples in the three nutrition survey villages (Yao, Chewa and Ngoni) and in the surrounding areas experienced much interaction and as, especially, patrilineal Ngoni interacted with matrilineal Chewa, practices usually associated with one or another of these descent systems became mutually modified rather than unidirectional. Aspects of patriliney actually failed to give advantage to many people, and aspects of matriliney – such as inheritance, rights to land, and control over labor and children – proved to be more durable than her interpretations implied.

Keywords ■ colonial history ■ gender ■ Malawi ■ Margaret Read ■ matriliney ■ nutrition ■ Nyasaland

The old Chewa and Yao form of marriage, known to anthropologists as matrilineal, by which a man built a house in his wife's village, and worked for his parents in law, is gradually giving way to a modified patrilineal form, known as . . . *chilengwa*. By this, the husband takes the wife to live in his village, but the children are usually sent back to the wife's mother in her village. Emigration is speeding up this change for two reasons. The first is that during the husband's absence the wife's morals can be better watched over by his relatives, who are also under an obligation to help her with cultivating, housebuilding, etc. The second is that the husband on returning home is sure of finding a food supply in his own village, whereas his wife in her village might have grown lazy and been living off her mother. The sequel to this form of patrilineal marriage will be sooner or later a demand for a change over to patrilineal inheritance and custody of the children. This is already being expressed in some areas, and I was asked a great many questions about parental authority and inheritance in the patrilineal line in England. (LSE/READ 1/38)

Interpreting African interactions of patrilineal and matrilineal practices in the late 1930s and early 1940s from the viewpoint of the returning male

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migrant laborer, from her understanding of Ngoni life, and from her own cultural and economic experiences, Margaret Read succeeded in distorting the way most people lived. Her approach presumed 'ideal types' and total 'systems'; it viewed these 'systems' in 'opposition'; and it led to the conclusion that matriliney was bad for agricultural practices, was deficient, and would be 'taken over' by a more efficient patriliney.

In this article, I re-examine the Nyasaland evidence provided by Read and her own use of it, and I argue that Read falsely privileged patriliney, male perspective, her idea of a 'permanent' elementary family, and husbands' needs. Her evidence does not bear out her conclusions that patriliney is a whole system in direct conflict with matriliney or that its dominant effects were beneficial. Her interpretations obscured the mixing and accommodation of aspects from both ideologies, and supported European interpretations about the non-viability of matrilineal practices.

The sources for this paper are largely unpublished.² What they reveal belies Read's presentation of patriliney's beneficence and prevalence. In 1938–9, following her three years of research on the patrilineal Ngoni, Read worked on two projects. She collected data in central Nyasaland as anthropologist for the three-village interdisciplinary Nyasaland (Malawi) Nutrition Survey, and, having been commissioned by Nyasaland's governor, she designed and supervised questionnaire surveys in 106 additional northern Nyasaland villages on the impact of migrant labor on village life (Read, 1942). In her interpretations of the data, she reaffirmed her belief that matriliney undermined family stability (especially because it was bad for the returning emigrant men), and hampered African agricultural production. She, and the agricultural officer of the nutrition survey, Richard Kettlewell, separately reported their shared assumption that patriliney was prevailing over matriliney.³ Both supported a shift to patriliney, although Kettlewell made his views much clearer than did Read.

The only published results from either of Read's studies are the preliminary findings from the 4-month survey of migrant labor's impact on village life. Her promised fuller studies never emerged, nor did the more general results of the Nyasaland Nutrition Survey.⁴ Nevertheless, in both the preliminary migrant labor report (1942) and her later books based on the completed Ngoni research⁵ (1956, 1960), she proposed the superiority of the principles of patriliney. I believe that, as a result of her prior notions of patrilineal superiority, Read saw interactions between patrilineal Ngoni and matrilineal Chewa 'through Ngoni eyes'.

Audrey Richards's Legacy

Anthropological understanding about African matriliney was just emerging in the late 1930s, mostly from the work of Audrey Richards on matrilineal

Bemba practices. Since Read and Richards had been fellow anthropology students at the London School of Economics (LSE), Read was familiar with Richards's articles (1934, 1935a, 1935b, 1936; Richards and Widdowson, 1936), though Richards's book, *Land, Labour and Diet*, was published in 1939 while Read was in Nyasaland. Read's work was done a decade before Richards's 1950 article on matrilineal family structure identified the extensiveness of matriliney in what Richards termed the 'matrilineal belt' (of central African Bantu, which stretched from the western Congo to the northern Rhodesia plateau and Nyasaland) (1950: 207). Like Read, Richards's first work had examined patrilineal African societies. In her doctoral thesis, which she finished in 1930 and published in 1932 as *Hunger and Work in a Savage Tribe*, Richards combed the existing secondary evidence on the southeastern Bantu and concluded they were nutritionally successful. She found no evidence of the annual 'hunger season' such as she later found among Bemba. She did not explore the contributions of cattle-keeping to food security, and, unlike her later work on the Bemba, she ignored many of the changes in agriculture wrought by colonialism. Read, too, tended to depict Ngoni in Nyasaland as less affected by their conquest and subsequent interaction with Chewa and other matrilineal groups. She acknowledged extensive migrations, vast changes and much interaction, but she presented all of these mostly as if Ngoni were modeling the changes rather than vice versa. The one exception was her acknowledgement that dietary preferences of sour milk, meat and sorghum had fallen by the wayside.

The interpretation of matriliney and patriliney as opposed types began earlier with Bronislaw Malinowski, the teacher of Richards and Read. He had encouraged Richards to undertake research in a matrilineal society, specifically to see its contrasts with patriliney (LSE/MAL 496). Jane Guyer (1981) argues effectively that patriliney and matriliney are oversimplified labels and that they do not represent closed and complete systems, but in the 1930s these two terms, along with matrilocal and patrilocal residence, were conceptualized and used this way by Read, Richards and Malinowski. Only after she had been in the field was Richards able to address the complexities of real societies. In her early 1930s study of Bemba diet, she documented significant undernutrition, which she attributed mostly to the failure of the *citimene* agricultural system to cope with the labor emigration of men. One indirect implication was that the inability of the Bemba to feed themselves properly could be attributed to matrilineal practices (Richards, 1935b) because many Bemba men, leaving for migrant work, ceased giving bride service to their wife's parents. Richards reported that husbands began giving small money payments for brides (1935b), and changing from an uxorilocal to a virilocal residence pattern, interpreting these changes as a 'breakdown' of traditional society. It was not known at the time that *citimene* did not reflect the agricultural practice of most matrilineal societies nor

that as a system it would remain so durable (Moore and Vaughan, 1987, 1994), but because Richards emphasized 'breakdown', and was fearful of societal collapse (wrongly, according to Moore and Vaughan, 1994), it was not she who argued that patriliney was taking over matriliney, but rather Read, whose views came to be dominant. Examined more closely, even the situations which Read documented were much more complex.⁶

The Nyasaland Nutrition Survey

The initial stimulus for an African nutrition survey, which was eventually conducted in Nyasaland, came from a committee within the International Institute of African Language and Cultures (IILAC)⁷ in which Audrey Richards played an active part because of her anthropological work on Bemba diet. Ultimately the purpose of the survey was to understand African nutritional status and African production systems, through the new science of nutrition (Worboys, 1987), medical research and the social context which anthropology could provide. The original plan was to study a single 'tribal' diet over an entire year (PRO/CAB/58/199), but was expanded in a colonial office committee to include a comparison of different ethnic groups in different ecological areas with different foods in which an interdisciplinary team would observe three villages over an annual agricultural cycle (PRO/CAB/58/208).

The Nyasaland villages were selected with the aim of comparing lakeshore cassava-growers with escarpment and plateau maize-growers. Unlike maize, cassava could be harvested all year round and did not have a restricted planting and harvesting cycle. The specific villages were chosen because they were familiar to the British medical and agricultural officers on the team, and because one was an Ngoni village, which allowed the team to take advantage of Read's anthropological expertise. The fact that the designated villages included patrilineal Ngoni, matrilineal Chewa and Yao, and some Ngoni-Chewa mixture was simply coincidental, but, as will be seen, revealed variations of practice.

The villages, located just west of Nkotakota, on the southwest shore of Lake Nyasa, included a lakeshore village (1200') of 30 Yao households, a hillside village (3000') of 30 Chewa households, and a plateau village (4500') of 55 Ngoni households.⁸ Even though travel up and down the escarpment was difficult, especially in the rainy season, the villages were close enough for the team to work in all three of them, though unevenly. Although the villages were treated as discrete types by the survey team, Read's research reveals their complexities, which had implications for nutritional quality. For instance, the Yao lakeshore village was almost exclusively Christian, and was surrounded by mixed villages of Chewa, Yao and Nyamwezi people who were Muslims. Its numbers had been declining for years and its female members

far outnumbered the males. Even though all villagers traced descent to a single matrilineal ancestor, they remained divided between those who were freeborn and those descended from slave wives. Moreover, internal competitiveness overcame cooperation, apparently because of the increasing emphasis on the monogamous nuclear family and the desire for material goods and education. In contrast, the Chewa hillside village included three hamlets forced together for tax purposes by the colonial administration, which had made the youngest and least-respected leader of one hamlet the village headman. His privileging Christian, Ngoni, and Western ways over Chewa traditions offended most members of the other two hamlets. The Ngoni village on the plateau included two Chewa extended families and also had extensive economic and kinship connections with a village their Ngoni chief had established 18 miles away.

Disruptions and Adjustments

The people of these three villages had been exposed to serious disruptions, which Read knew well. By 1860, Swahili slave traders from the east had established themselves along the west coast of the lake. One, Jumbe, made his headquarters at Nkotakota, whence he made many raids on the peoples along the lake and westward up the escarpment and across the plateau. From the west, Ngoni warriors from the Mzimba hills raided down the escarpment to the lakeshore for foodstuffs, ivory and captives. Africans residing in the area essentially became dependants, either of the Jumbe at Nkotakota or the Ngoni at Dowa. For 40 years until 1900 most of the people in this area lived in concentrated, sometimes fortified, communities.

Adding to the earlier warfare and slavery experiences were three major 20th-century forces that contributed to extensive transformation: colonial rule, the money economy and Christianity. The colonial administration restricted African movements and reformed political units, contributing directly to the ways in which people organized around matriliney or patriliney interacted. Once peace had brought an end to the need to live in stockaded villages and the systems of slavery or clientship were abolished, villages not only spread out, but the colonial system made their new locations permanent and overlaid them with new criteria for authority. This process virtually ended shifting cultivation, limited the size of plots, severely constrained the mobility of villages and, in some cases, drew groups together that barely functioned as units. Actually, all three survey villages were relatively new. Two hamlets of the hillside Chewa had returned from Dowa to their old village area in 1900, while the other hamlet had gained nearby land in 1904 (LSE/READ 1/27H). The lakeshore Yao, who had originally come to the area in 1876, first tried to live inland where they could grow maize, but when the warring stopped and Jumbe allocated them rights to

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land at the lakeshore in 1910, they moved near the lake and resigned themselves to being in a cassava area (LSE/READ 1/27L). The plateau Ngoni were the last of these three villages to settle. They moved to their present site from Mzandu, 7 miles down the escarpment, in 1914. They 'begged' the new land from the resident Chewa 'owner', in this case a man who had literally once been their slave (NNS/READ 3-7).

The second transforming force for these villagers was their being thrust into a money economy when the hut tax began to be collected 'vigorously' in this area in 1915 and 1916 (Vail, 1989: 173). Here, tax, as in so many places where there were few nearby opportunities for paid labor, was linked to the beginning of emigrant wage work from the three villages and stimulated their attempts to grow cash crops. Matrilineal practices were directly affected in two ways. Absent men could not perform bride service, and families lost control over a son-in-law's labor even though he might give them a portion of his wage instead. Second, a matrilineal man's duty as a brother, with responsibilities to distribute wealth to his sister's children, was more easily modified when he acquired a wage or controlled proceeds from a cash crop. In contrast, young men in patrilineal societies were better able to acquire the means for brideprice. Read argued that the biggest (and uneven) impact on food production and marriage patterns was caused by the number of men away, the duration of their stay, the attitudes they acquired about 'modern' society, and their contribution to, or abandonment of, their families in the villages (LSE/READ 1/27).

Christianity, a third force, also had an uneven impact on the three villages. People in the Yao village, 5 miles inland from the lakeshore town of Nkotakota, had virtually all been converted to Anglo-Catholicism through the Universities' Mission to central Africa, established since 1895 (Blood, 1962). A new marriage form emerged which counteracted some of the elements of matriliney. A Dutch Reformed Church had opened in 1909 on the upper escarpment, just about equidistant from the other two villages. Ten adults (25%) from the hillside Chewa village and fourteen adults (16%) from the plateau Ngoni village had been baptized. In the hillside village, Christian identity contributed to internal friction as non-Christians and Christians became severely divided. On the plateau, it seemed to have little impact on the coherence and cooperation within the Ngoni village, and in fact, might have been regarded as another resource available to villagers, since it posed no conflicts with patrilineal patterns.

Despite colonial Christian and commercial patrilineal influences which enhanced previous Swahili and Ngoni ones, the primary socio-economic ideology guiding practice in this larger Nkotakota region came from the numerically dominant matrilineal Chewa, and much about the Yao pattern was similar. Chewa had once been part of a larger centralized Maravi state, but power had decentralized to the village level, where the highest political authority, by the time of the study in 1938, was in the hands of the male

head (*nkhoswe*) of the local matrilineal group (*mbumba*). In this region, the term *banja* is used generally as 'family', but can refer specifically to kin groups as well as households (cf. Davison, 1993; Peters, 1994). In 1939, Read used the term *banja* to refer to each of the primary divisions within a village. For instance, the lakeshore village was a single *banja* despite the fact that the inhabitants were divided between those born of free mothers and those whose mothers had been slaves. The hillside village had three *banjas*, reflecting the three hamlets. The plateau village had three Ngoni and one Chewa *banja* (LSE/READ 1/25). Two generations before the study, virtually all of the Chewa marriages were between cross-cousins, which kept husband and wife in the same village, and questions of gifts and residence did not arise. Read's evidence generally reflects what Phiri later presented as a set of ideal practices of Chewa matriliney. Young girls married immediately after puberty (12–14 years), but boys, who were older, had to demonstrate housebuilding, agricultural, and craft skills first. The *nkhoswe* as guardian facilitated marriages of his sisters. The husband-to-be gave a small token gift to the bride's parents, and before the marriage was completed, he began giving bride service (*chikamwini*) (Bruwer, 1949; Phiri, 1983: 260). Only after many children were born and the wife's family agreed could the husband, if he were from another village, make a token payment and take his wife to his own village, which was usually in walking distance, close enough for all of the family members to see each other frequently. The children belonged to the mother's matrilineage, and older children, especially the eldest daughter, were sent back to live with their grandmothers. A husband had to make a death payment (*camtupa*) to the matrilineage when his wife died. Inheritance passed from the mother's brother to her children (LSE/READ 1/25).

The basic unit of production in the hillside village was the household, and husbands and wives both contributed extensively to agricultural work, though they usually did not perform the same tasks.⁹ Women without husbands suffered from the loss of their labor unless they had money to hire replacement laborers, although communal beer parties were widely used (LSE/READ 1/25; NNS/1–5). Rights to land in this region, which for a long time had been exclusively Chewa, were obtained from the male matrilineal 'owner', the male head of the matrilineage, or *nkhoswe*. He established his own village site, and held the rights to hold initiations (*mzinda*). He set the time for the initiation rites for women (*cinamwali*), which were critical because the fertility of the land was believed to be directly related to the health of the women of the matrilineage. The *nkhoswe* controlled the rights to woodlands and uncultivated grasslands, gave permission for the first grass burning, and received some parts of all wild animals hunted by villagers. This process had facilitated shifting agriculture and village movements. Although among their southern Yao, Mang'anja and Lomwe neighbors, women were sometimes official village leaders, in this central area, Read reported that so long as sisters had a living brother, this brother was the

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guardian of the village. Once the last surviving brother died, a family formed around each sister and her uterine descendants under the leadership of her eldest son (LSE/READ 1/30).¹⁰ Chewa men belonged to the *nyau* secret society,¹¹ which Phiri argues provided temporary escape from the restrictions on their roles as uxori-local husbands because, when they were meeting and dancing (which they did especially for initiations and funerals), they were above the law of the community (Phiri, 1983: 261). According to the survey evidence, when the dancing groups arrived at a village, they were always fed, so *nyau* men gained extra benefits during food shortages (NNS/READ 34).

This basic description of daily living is generally appropriate for the Yao village (cf. Roberts, 1964), except that Yao men were often involved in trading, and their absence from home led to a pattern allowing them to acquire wives without providing bride service. Yao men were known to eschew agricultural work, and they traditionally worked less in the fields than did Chewa men (Vaughan, 1982: 356). Yao had similar male 'guardians', secret societies¹² and female rituals.

Several things seem clear from this general picture. Women were highly valued as reproducers of a matrilineage and as agricultural producers; children belonged to matrilineages; the roles of husband, father and son were overshadowed by the role of maternal brother; and the conjugal unit seemed secondary to the overriding needs of the matrilineage. According to Read, divorce was easy, especially since it carried no penalties (LSE/READ 1/27L).

To all of the survey researchers, but especially to Read, the highly centralized Ngoni patrilineal organization offered a marked contrast to matriliney. Ngoni had conquered Chewa in this area around 1875, but after the *Pax Britannica* at the turn of the century, when people began to return to their homes, those Ngoni on the plateau were a numerical minority living amongst, and intermarrying with, Chewa. Like most Ngoni in the central region, those in the survey plateau village spoke Nyanja, the language of their Chewa dependants.¹³ They also maintained links with other Ngoni villages within a 12-to-20-mile radius. Their strongly patrilineal ideology was much like that Richards had described for the southeastern Bantu and was drawn from their own Zulu roots, but when Read described how this ideal had been amended, she gave modifications of old patrilineal practices rather than adaptations of new matrilineal ones.

In Ngoni ideal practices, brideprice (*lobola*) was paid in cattle, divorce was rare because brideprice had to be returned, and wives lived virilocally. Polygamy, commonly practised, usually represented wealth. Society was organized on the basis of age-sets, which had once facilitated military regiments, and 'big houses', which represented local chiefly power. Diet had included sour milk, meat, and porridge and beer from millet and sorghum. In this plateau village, according to Read, wives still lived virilocally,

brideprice was paid in specie rather than cattle, and divorce was still difficult. Polygyny remained, often due to the inheritance of a deceased brother's wife rather than as a mark of greater wealth. Age-sets functioned in only a limited way, but male elders retained control over the women and the young men, though the latter resisted and viewed emigrant labor as a means of escape. Following Ngoni tradition, their chief formed two 'big houses' under the authority of his two senior wives, and every household in the village (except those in the Chewa hamlets) became attached to one of these two 'big houses'. The sense of mutual obligation was strong. The 'houses' controlled the two granaries, the few cattle and wages of returning migrant workers. With the loss of large cattle herds to rinderpest in the late 19th century, and their move to different territory, Ngoni had foregone some of their previous dietary preferences (for meat, sour milk), and they could not grow enough of their favorite grains (sorghum and millet). Like their Chewa neighbors, they ate sticky maize porridge (*nsima*) which they dipped into a sauce made mostly of vegetables. Since this village had few cattle, and herding was no longer the main occupation of men, men worked, as did their wives, in the family fields, and young men were required to work with their age-mates to help with food production (LSE/READ 1/27P). As will be seen below, Read omitted the concessions and adaptations these Ngoni had made to matriliney.

The Evidence and the Issues

How had matriliney and patriliney fared under these vast changes of intermixture and disruption from slavery, warfare, Islam, colonialism and mission activities? In all cases there is evidence of marriage and residential modification. On the plateau, where one might have expected most marriages in the Ngoni village to involve brideprice (*lobola*), and on the hillside, where one might have expected bride service (*chikamwini*) marriages to dominate, the majority of marriages in both villages reflected what Read referred to as a 'half-way stage' (LSE/READ 1/27H) between the two previous forms, called *chitengwa*,¹⁴ which essentially facilitated a change to virilocal residence. Whereas *lobola* involved a series of gifts in instalments, often cattle or goats, *chitengwa* involved a one-time gift (worth anywhere from two shillings to one pound, or from a fowl to a sheep) which was given by the groom to his wife's family (usually the mother's brother). In return, the man was allowed to take his wife to live in his village, but he had to allow elder children to go to the mother's family and he still agreed to pay a death fee. *Chitengwa* changed residence but did not displace *chikamwini*. Read's interpretation was that *chitengwa* was a 'compromise between matrilineal and patrilineal descent and residence' and that it 'reflects Ngoni influence' (LSE/READ 1/27H).

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The Chewa hillside village had 21 traditional *chikamwini* marriages, 26 *chitengwa* marriages, and no *lobola* marriages (LSE/READ 1/27H). Two generations previously, marriages almost all entailed *chikamwini* and most were between cross-cousins. Read fails to acknowledge that this change might have been brought about by forces other than Ngoni influence, especially the end of shifting cultivation. In this village, *chitengwa* marked a change from uxorilocality to virilocality, but almost all moves were within 5 miles of the wife's parents, and the full authority of the matrilineage over children was retained.

In the patrilineal plateau village, where Read says the typical form of marriage was *lobola* (although there were only 20 of them compared with 37 *chitengwa* and 21 *chikamwini*, the latter mostly among the Chewa families), she interprets *chitengwa* as a transition: 'it is likely that the other *chitengwa* marriages will be converted later on to *lobola*' (LSE/READ 1/27P). Given the extensive Ngoni-Chewa intermarriages in this village, including three of the chief's wives, much more than a smaller payment was involved, since *chitengwa* included the retention of Chewa matrilineal rights to land, to children and compensation for a wife's death. Thus, Chewa influences remained as significant as those of Ngoni, and influence was going in both directions.

When an Ngoni man married a Chewa wife, his was a *chitengwa* marriage, and the wife came to live in his village while he took on the obligations to her matrilineage (LSE/READ 1/27P). Read's evidence never states whether children in cases where Ngoni men married Chewa women belonged to their mother's matrilineage, but she implies that this is the case, since in all three survey villages some children were living in a village other than that of their parents (NNS/READ 22). The pattern of Ngoni establishing gardens along streambeds in the surrounding Chewa villages on the plateau reflect marriages whereby a husband could benefit from his wife's rights to the land.¹⁵ Moreover, *chitengwa* allowed an increasing number of Ngoni men to avoid paying extensive *lobola*, even when they were marrying Ngoni women. Phiri (1983: 266–7)¹⁶ recounts that those Ngoni who were descended from Ciwere at Dowa (as was true for the Ngoni in the plateau village) had incorporated many Chewa institutions; Read saw all changes as Ngoni influence.

The lakeshore village reported that the marriage pattern two generations previously had been one of matrilineal cross-cousin marriages. As the villagers converted to Christianity, however, a new form of marriage developed which they called *chimangiso* which, according to Read, was 'not unlike the *lobola* marriage of the Ngoni in some of its features' (LSE/READ 1/27L). A significant money payment (approximately two to three pounds sterling) was given to the bride's *parents* (and not the mother's brother) (NNS/READ 14), and had to be returned in case of divorce. The wife went to reside with her husband, who was not liable for a payment to her

matrilineal group upon her death. Christian marriages were monogamous and children were under the care of both parents but the 'children will be taken care of by his [the father's] relatives' (LSE/READ 1/27L). These adaptations facilitated more durable marriages, favored the role of husband over brother, and established the conjugal family as an independent unit which was supposed to gain patrilineal control over children. In 1939 there were still 4 cross-cousin marriages out of 22 in the lakeshore village, and every woman in the village was linked by matrilineal bonds to at least one of the 16 men in residence (LSE/READ 1/25), so male conflicts between men's roles as brothers and as husbands emerged, especially in regard to their unmarried or widowed sisters. Unusual in a matrilineal society, more women married out of this village than men, but because so many of the men were absent, this discrepancy was less evident (LSE/READ 1/27).

Read considered that the degree and pattern of male emigrant labor had the greatest impact on food production and marriage forms in these villages. Just over half of the men from the hillside and plateau villages were away in 1939, but over 70 percent of the men were gone from the lakeshore village. Whereas men from the foothill village left for an average of three years, usually to hoe or carry loads, and men from the plateau village left for four or five years and headed to the mines or to work in stores or be houseboys, lakeshore men were gone for more than a decade, usually working as labor managers on estates, and they garnered the largest salaries. When identifying men who had never returned (*machona*), both the hillside and plateau villages counted 10, but 20 men from the lakeshore village had 'disappeared' (LSE/READ 1/27, 1/32; NNS/READ 19–20). Though the lakeshore villagers had most closely followed the model of westernization and had the most secure food crop, some of them still experienced the greatest difficulty acquiring food, and the difference was distinctly gendered.

Given that, in all three villages, more than several women were left without husbands to help them, how did they fare? In the Chewa hillside village, where 11 households were without the labor of a husband, communal labor helped most to overcome the loss, and the loss seemed lessened since husbands, brothers and sons usually returned after three years (NNS/READ 11). Yet despite predictable, annual hungry months, and constant discussion and concern about food shortages, survey calculations found this village to have the best overall record of food consumed in relation to energy expended (NNS/II-10). Women without husbands had several options. As young wives, they worked their mothers' gardens. Some went to call on kin in other villages, but most of them worked on other people's farms in exchange for food (*kusuma*) (NNS/READ 11). Although this latter practice was considered to be demeaning by some, it was used consistently and effectively by these villagers.

Among the plateau Ngoni, 15 households were without the labor of a

husband (10 women had husbands away and 5 women were widowed or divorced) but Read argued for several compensating factors. Polygyny in 27 households facilitated cooperation among co-wives, and the chief's authority and the availability of youthful men in junior age-sets ensured that all women were given assistance in maintaining their agricultural fields. The common granaries of the two 'houses' and the complex of cooking and eating groups across households also overcame any food shortages these women otherwise might suffer. Read viewed this village to be more agriculturally successful than the findings of the nutritional survey revealed, and, although she did not attribute that success directly to patriliney, she associated the factors of chiefly power, house authority, co-wives, and complex cooking and eating groups with patrilineal practices (LSE/READ 1/27P).

At the lakeshore, where the Yao village had changed to a pattern of individualism and monogamous households, 25 women were without the labor of their husbands (9 wives with husbands away, and 13 women who were widowed or divorced) and, in addition, there were 13 young women past puberty who were unmarried and still living with their mothers. With 26 single males away from this village and little expectation that they would return soon, the remaining unmarried women had a difficult time finding acceptable husbands from among the surrounding Muslim Chewa, and there were no unmarried men in the village over age 15. This village then, composed of 16 men and 51 women, had the greatest number of people with desperate food circumstances. All of them were women in female-headed households. Providing sufficient cassava was *not* the main problem, since cassava could be produced solely by the women's labor, but cassava alone was insufficiently nourishing. The most nutritious, desirable, and theoretically available complementary food was fish, but this presented a problem. For a few months a year, women used special traps to catch small fish found in the tiny lagoon near the village, but fishing in the main lagoon and the lake was restricted to men only. Fishing traps were associated with such taboos, magic and complexities that nets and traps were never even inherited (NNS/II-7). Women without husbands, brothers, or sons to provide fish had to do without or have the resources to purchase fish. No evidence exists that brothers in this village assisted their sisters to acquire fish. It was hard to rely on a greatly diminished system of sharing reduced by the greater expenses required by a higher standard of living and education.

The desire for the higher standard of living was dividing this village into classes and militating against assistance. In a situation rather unusual in eastern central Africa, women at the lakeshore had almost full control over a cash crop – labor-intensive rice. Most of this arduous work they did alone, assisted only by paid labor. They came to be responsible for paying school fees and for buying clothes for their children without counting on

additional help from their brothers or their husbands or from their children's labor. Fathers, when questioned as to why *they* were not paying school fees, replied, 'They have their mother. I cannot be made poor because of them' (LSE/READ 1/30: 3). Children's comments indicate the pressure on their mothers, many of whom had wage-earning husbands and brothers. 'We ask our mothers for school fees and for clothes and for pennies because we know they find money by selling rice and firewood and other things' (LSE/READ 1/30: 2).

Read noted with approval that men in the Yao lakeshore village kept personal control of wages and that they spent them on their elementary family, but she expressed surprise that some matrilineal distribution patterns remained. A few men had solitary plots, and they would give proceeds to their sisters and their children, a move which, according to Read, did not 'follow ordinary household rules of distribution'. Proceeds from women's own plots went to their children (LSE/READ 1/30: 5).

Drawing upon their ranking in the matrilineage and their reputation in the Christian community, three women were responsible for most of the community decisions in the lakeshore village, especially decisions relating to feeding the women who had no husbands. It was not brothers who came to the rescue of their sisters in women-headed households; few men cultivated solitary plots. It was the village women who provided the most help. While Read saw here the greatest pattern of change from matrilineal to patrilineal practices, she also saw the people (all women) who were the most vulnerable nutritionally and she predicted that this village would disintegrate (LSE/READ 1/25: IV). Her example here for a patrilineal takeover was hardly positive.

Patrilineal Preferences?

At first, then, in the view of researchers who expected that patriliney ranked higher on some imaginary evolutionary scale and would prevail over matriliney, it *appeared* as if the Yao lakeshore village showed that patriliney was prevailing over matriliney. Yet this was not entirely the case. Aspects of matriliney persisted, particularly regarding distribution and control over land, though practices were selective. It also *appeared* that Ngoni were influencing a trend among Chewa that Read interpreted as one toward patriliney. In fact, the trend was toward virilocality, and the changes regarding marital payments were going both ways. Moreover, in the more popular form of marriage, *chitengwa*, even Ngoni men were agreeing that the first child belonged to the matrilineage and they agreed to pay *camtupa* upon their wife's death. Surely Read had seen evidence of even more extensive Ngoni modifications during her previous work, especially with Ciwere's Ngoni at Dowa. Ngoni there apparently not only practised matrilineal descent and

inheritance rules but adopted *nyau* secret societies and women's village initiation rites (Hodgson, 1933: 106; Langworthy, 1975: 21; Stuart, 1974: 162–3). Lucy Mair found that Ngoni in nearby Dedza district retained patrilineal succession but had 'almost without exception' adopted the Chewa marriage practice of the husband going to reside in the wife's home (1951: 104).

A more general misreading of the evidence as a change to patriliney was probably due to Read's view (and Kettlewell's as well) that there were different patrilineal and matrilineal agriculture practices: the former system was practical, based on the organizational capabilities of the chief; the latter foolishly relied on magic, and was more superstitious and primitive (LSE/READ 1/27). Some in the hillside village attributed their long hunger period, which seemed greater than that of their neighbors, to the Christian headman's inattentiveness to the spirits (NNS/READ 18). Read interpreted the fact that matrilineal wives with husbands away usually reduced the size of their fields after two years as a decline of agricultural practices (NNS/READ 28). Kettlewell believed that Ngoni men made good 'model farmers', but that Chewa and Yao men were not interested (NNS/II-V; Berry and Petty, 1992: 233). When the survey team launched an agricultural experiment to dam a stream stocked with fish surrounded by fruit trees, Kettlewell helped to pick a spot near the plateau village because he believed the Ngoni to be more progressive. The villagers did not tend the experimental area, and the project was a complete failure (CLB:L).

So what *was* the role of the matrilineage in food production? Unlike the Bemba, as described by Richards (1939: 384), the Nyasaland villages did not take the matrilineage as the basis for organizing agricultural labor. In the Chewa hillside village, the primary production unit was a woman and her husband, if he was available, but village-based work parties for beer were common at peak periods (LSE/READ 1/30H) and other assistance was gained through reciprocal labor, labor for food, paid labor, or gift and gossip labor. Children helped very little (NNS/V-5). Rather than matrilineal relationship, the factions based on political rivalry between hamlets and in Christian versus non-Christian affiliation (and alcoholic versus non-alcoholic beer) provided the basis for cooperative work.

At the lakeshore, where all of the villagers were descendants from the matrilineal family of Liwewe and virtually all were Anglo-Catholic Christian, work was not shared on the basis of birth status, and the spirit of individualism overrode communal work. Women did most of the work and cultivated cassava without much help from their husbands. The most assistance was needed to cultivate rice, the cash crop, and almost all labor was paid in cash. It appears that the spirit of *cinasi*, or neighborliness, provided whatever basis existed for cohesion and sharing, but economic competition and economic secrecy kept this from evolving into charity (LSE/READ 1/25).

The Christian basis for sharing was never mentioned, and some of the most and the least successful food production prevailed here, but the existence of a single matrilineage made no difference whatsoever.

Women's Roles

The key problem in Read's interpretations is that she seemed able to see only disadvantages related to matriliney, to which she attributed the instability of families and agricultural decline. She was both reflecting a more widespread colonial prejudice and seeming to provide evidence that women were responsible for the 'problems'. Because she appears to have repeated men's opinions rather than those of women whose problems involved survival in the village in men's absence, she even argued indirectly that women could not effectively be in charge:

The fact that women in matrilineal tribes tend to cultivate less land and depend on their mother's food supplies is the main reason for an increase in a modified partilocal [actually virilocal] form of marriage among the matrilineal Chewa. . . . [The wife] ceased to cultivate her own land at all and [the husband] would be dependent upon the charity of his mother-in-law. (1942: 628-9)

She argued that women's isolation made them more conservative because they were fearful of social disapproval and possible accusations of witchcraft. As she stated bluntly: 'The situation then is one where many of the men are definitely aiming at a higher standard of living, but the dead weight of the women is pulling them back' (Read, 1942: 629). In her discussions with villagers about the impact of emigration, she was told that male emigrants viewed the village to be in squalor compared with town life. Though they admitted that the women's arduous duties of hoeing, fetching firewood and water, pounding grain, cooking and childcare left them with hardly any time to be housekeepers, she argued that 'when women were left for long periods without a husband to keep house for, they became careless cooks and made no efforts to maintain their household and children on the level which their husband expected' (Read, 1942: 627).

Not everybody read the evidence that the matrilineal uxrilocal homestead was detrimental in and of itself to agriculture. In his draft report of the nutrition survey, Platt added to Read's comments about the disadvantage of matriliney: 'On the other hand, his [an emigrant's] family may in this case have a less hard time during his absence than the wife and children of an absentee under the patrilocal marriage system' (NNS/II-13; MRC/PLATT 2167). Viewed from the women's perspective, Richards noted that 'women were happier in a matrilocal community if they are to be deserted for some years' (1940: 39). Marwick commented on this in his

1952 study of the kinship basis of Zambian Cewa¹⁷ social structure. 'In particular it seems that because the matrilineage remains functional under a disturbed sex-ratio, Cewa society appears to be better adapted to a high labour migration rate than might be the case with a conjugally organized people' (1952: 261). He further argued that the only changes he had been able to find of Cewa matrilineal social organization giving way in the face of patrilineal Ngoni and European-Christian influences have been very superficial: 'A century of Ngoni, and a half-century of European dominance and influence have done little to disturb the fundamentally matrilineal character of the social structure' (1952: 262).

There was ample evidence of general failure to meet colonial agricultural expectations, but Read seemed to be confusing women's residence with the larger issue of access to, and control over, agricultural fields. Chanock directly challenged Read's interpretations about matriliney and agriculture:

Margaret Read likewise persuaded herself, with the help of Ngoni informants, that the Ngoni were responsible for the prosperity of the agricultural area. Yet it seems more realistic to see the Ngoni . . . as overlords of a tribute economy and the exploiters of an agriculture which was often damaged, rather than created, by their presence. (1977: 400, citing Read, 1971)

He also challenged Kettlewell who, in a post-colonial context, had written:

The matrilineal system, it was felt, was a part and parcel of backwardness, as a man apparently had no incentive to improve his land, 'over which he had tenuous and transitory tenure and no prospect of handing it on to his son'. (1965: 238)

Here, Kettlewell seems to be presuming private ownership of land by men as a goal. Chanock also pointed out that the evidence contradicted Read's and Kettlewell's preconceived notions:

The fact that during the colonial period it was the matrilineal areas which, outside the estates, rapidly became the main producers of the agricultural surplus, and the patrilineal ones where agriculture appeared to decay, apparently passed unnoticed. (1977: 404)

When Richards noted:

The fact is surely that the Bemba woman is in a freer position living among her own people and is co-operating with those she is most closely identified with, but she is less controlled in her movements, has greater rights of divorce and remarriage and her marriage is apparently less strong . . . (1940: 39)

she, too, indicated a possible problem, but only if seen from a perspective that viewed marriage stability and husbands' needs as paramount.

Current Status of the Villages

The greatest test of Read's conclusions is whether the survey villages continued along the path of 'progress' to patriliney. By 1992 when I conducted field research in the original survey villages I found them still in their earlier locations, though the housing sites had shifted, often across the road, and each had declined in size.¹⁸ The Chief's court on the plateau was now a Chewa court rather than an Ngoni one, reflecting the majority population of the region. The two factions in the hillside village were still quarreling; once again they had applied to the government to be separated into two distinct villages. The households of the plateau Ngoni village had been reduced from 53 to 29, and a local agricultural officer indicated that he wasn't surprised, given the poor quality of the soil there. The hillside Chewa had reduced from 30 to 22 households. At the lakeshore, by 1992 there were only half as many households as there had been at the time of the survey, and only 7 of the 14 remaining households represented the original Liwewe matrilineage. Most people had left the hillside and plateau villages in groups because they could obtain better land elsewhere for growing food and cash crops, especially tobacco. Some of the plateau Ngoni (along with some members of the Chewa hamlet which was a part of their plateau village) had moved to Ndabwi, the village founded in 1927 by their Ngoni village chief. Tobacco thrived there, and soil was better for maize. Some of the hillside Chewa (mostly from the Christian hamlet) moved away as a group onto the plateau at Kamsonga, joining some other Chewa kin. In contrast, lakeshore Yao apparently moved out as individuals. The problem for them was that, except for 'begging' land from others, they had no land rights except in this village; therefore many people moved permanently to urban areas. But other individuals moved in. Christian Chewa men married into the lakeshore village and, through their wives, gained rights to land. No longer was there an excess of unmarried women. In the generation following the survey, sons brought wives to live with them. This village, not surprisingly, now considers itself a mixed, rather than a Yao village, but the matrilineage based on the original Yao settlers still controls the use of the land and, even with the much-reduced numbers, there is still a land shortage. Here then, land usurped originally from Chewa by the slave-owner Jumbe was allotted to his Yao dependants and, through marriage, Chewa were making claims again. After many years, most of these villagers adopted virilocal, monogamous marriage patterns but retained matrilineal descent, inheritance, and land rights. The flexibility required by circumstance and the durability of the matrilineal inheritance are reflected in the current chief, who is the son of the previous chief's sister, yet a polygynous Muslim.

A virilocal *residence* pattern has certainly become more of the norm in all three villages, and bride service seems to be avoided if at all possible. At the same time, core aspects of matriliney prevail, most notably matrilineal

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control over land use and children belonging to the matrilineage. A woman's rights to land in her village are still viable, and in both matrilineal villages, I encountered several examples of a daughter coming back with her husband to her village and taking up her land claims. If, however, a husband left a village, the wife usually accompanied him. Based on the principle of women's rights to land, the plateau Ngoni have used their extensive intermarriage with neighboring Chewa to gain rights to gardens further from their own village. It seems as if a mixed practice prevails to privilege men so that they do not have to give bride service nor pay a large bride-price, but the ideology of matrilineage dominates and daughters of the matrilineage remain in a strong position regarding secure rights to land.

In their recently edited book on land tenure, Bassett and Crummey (1993) include no specific cases of matriliney, but data from the villages in the Nyasaland survey support many of the principles argued there against assuming that private, individualized, male-owned land is the best long-term survival strategy for Africa to provide good quality of life and communities that thrive.¹⁹ A new look at the matrilineal land tenure's long-term relationship to the need for wages and/or cash crops might show that such a lineage-related practice may provide workable strategies beyond the narrow ecological niches where agricultural yield is low (Douglas, 1969: 121). Once the extensive opportunities for migrant labor to South Africa were closed off in Malawi in the 1970s, more men had to spend more time producing food with their families, and patrilineal organization or virilocality seemed to have no distinct advantages for food production even for the returning male.

Conclusions

A close look at Read's evidence does not support the prevailing assumption of the slow but sure taking over of matriliney by patriliney. Most important, it shows that aspects of patriliney not only failed to give advantage to all people, but that women were often directly disadvantaged. Her evidence, when set in relation to other information, shows a much more complex situation of interaction and modification to mutual benefit. When Read left Nyasaland in 1939, her primary goal was to write her Ngoni book (which did not appear until 1956) and finish her report on emigrant labor (1942) (LSE/MAL 496). Interpreting aspects of matriliney was surely secondary, but the extensive evidence she collected belies the oversimplified interpretations which did get into print immediately.

The assumptions about matriliney in this region, more than the evidence, prevailed in the subsequent work undertaken by Kettlewell and in Read's publications. But, had the evidence, interpretations and results of the Nyasaland Nutrition Survey and the wider, comparative evidence of the

emigrant labor study been made available in the early 1940s, they would have shown *then* the ways in which Africans were accommodating and borrowing from the practices of 'patriliney' and 'matriliney'. It seems that the problem of maintaining separate and distinct 'systems' was one for Europeans rather than for the Africans themselves. Patriliney and matriliney were not dichotomous, complete systems in a conflict that 'patriliney' was sure to win, and, despite a widely held prejudice for patriliney and external structural elements which facilitated patriliney's continuation, aspects of matriliney prevailed. The modification Africans made maintained women's rights to land and, sometimes, to labor, and both of these durable aspects of matriliney seem to be serving well the difficult conditions of rural African agriculture.

Notes

- 1 This is a revision of my paper, 'Modifications of Matriliney: Central Nyasaland, 1939', African Studies Association, Toronto, Canada, 1994. I am grateful for comments from Pauline Peters, Jean Davison, Ed Steinhart, Margot Lovett, Phyllis Jestice, Francesca Miller, Ben Orlove, Jim Pritchett, and my 'research group' at University of California, Davis.
- 2 The main archival resources for this survey exist in the Centre for Human Nutrition (CHN), London School of Hygiene and Tropical Medicine, London; the British Medical Research Council (MRC); the British Library of Political and Economic Science (LSE); the Public Record Office (PRO) and oral interviews. See bibliography for specific listings.
- 3 Although Read left after her year of research, Kettlewell tried to implement changes based on his beliefs as he continued his work as an agricultural officer and became the Director of Agriculture for Nyasaland in the 1950s. He urged a change in Nyasaland land tenure to male-owned private holdings and helped to initiate the Master Farmer program which specifically provided land for male landholders in matrilineal areas (Kettlewell, 1965: 250, 275).
- 4 The materials from this survey have now been printed by Berry and Petty (1992). Because several versions of the reports exist, however, I rely on the archives for my citations.
- 5 When she wrote her Ngoni books, Read conveyed a single Ngoni political system for all of Nyasaland and implied it existed for all Ngoni. Vail and White (1989: 160, 182) see her view as an incorrect oversimplification.
- 6 I acknowledge the difficulties of the evidence here and that I am both using and critiquing Margaret Read's ethnographical evidence.
- 7 The precursor of IAI.
- 8 For easier identification for those readers unfamiliar with these villages, I am appending to my descriptions the ethnic identifiers as they were used at the time. The data on ethnic interaction even belies Read's own interpretation of Ngoni 'tribal' identity. The issue of the 'creation of tribes' in this instance is discussed by Vail (1989) and Vail and White (1989).
- 9 As will be seen later, although the household was the basic production unit in all three villages, in the lakeshore village, men did much less agricultural work and there were many female-headed households. In the plateau village, there existed several layers of available agricultural production assistance.

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- 10 Compare Fleming (1971: 57) for his findings in northern Malawi.
- 11 Woods (1992) argues that *nyau* was not an original part of Chewa culture, but came later.
- 12 The counterpart to *nyau* is *unyago*. Hodgson (1993: 146 n1) cites Stannus (nd: 252).
- 13 Even in northern Rhodesia, Read had found that Nyanja was the main spoken language of the Ngoni (LSE/MAL 496).
- 14 Read defines *chitengwa* as the Chewa term for the money payment to the wife's family involving virilocal marriage (LSE/READ 1/25 II) but Hodgson (1933: 139) derives it from *kutenga*, to take, so is the arrangement for virilocality. Phiri (1986: 262) agrees, and stresses it emerged from mutual agreement and was not granted for mere unhappiness.
- 15 LSE/READ 1/32. Plateau village garden map.
- 16 He cites Langworthy (1975: 1–20); Hodgson (1993: 106); Mair (1952: 104); and Stuart (1974: 162–3).
- 17 I am retaining Marwick's spelling of Cewa.
- 18 I expected (as Henrietta Moore and Megan Vaughan discovered regarding Audrey Richards's Bemba research villages) that the original Nyasaland Nutrition Survey villages might no longer exist. Read had certainly expected the lakeshore village to disintegrate. I anticipated that they might be so transformed as to be unrecognizable or perhaps even that they were no longer viable villages (Moore and Vaughan, 1994).
- 19 See especially Bassett, 'Introduction' and Bruce, Chapter 1.

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- 1 *Nyasaland Nutrition Survey Papers*, Centre for Human Nutrition, University of London
NNS/READ Margaret Read Notebook
NNS/I-V Archival Listing
- 2 *Margaret Read Papers*, London School of Economics
LSE/READ 1/25, 1/27, 1/30, 1/32
1/38 'Preliminary Report: Emigration from Nyasaland: Its Effects on Village Life', presented to the Native Welfare Committee in Nyasaland (nd, but probably 1940)
- 3 *Bronislaw Malinowski Papers*, London School of Economics
LSE/MAL 496 Margaret Read, Correspondence.
- 4 *B.S. Platt File*, Medical Research Council, London
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- 5 *Public Record Office London*
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- 6 *Brantley Interviews*, August 1992: CLB:L (Lakeshore); CLB:H (Hillside); CLB:P (Plateau).

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